



BEFORE

The Civil War was the result of years of conflict between the north and south.

NEW MEMBERS OF THE UNION

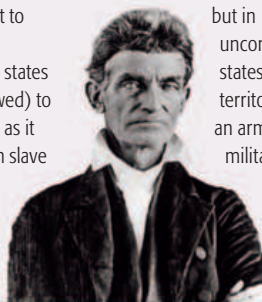
In the years following independence << 298–99, more territories joined the original 13 colonies of the United States (known as the Union).

SLAVERY

The Constitutional Convention of 1787 allowed **individual states to permit slavery**; northern states abolished it, while southern states kept it.

THE NORTH–SOUTH DIVIDE

The issue of slavery itself revolved around **state versus federal** rights, and whether a slave was a person's property, the right to which was guaranteed by the US Constitution. Admitting new free states (a state where slavery was outlawed) to the Union would be problematic, as it would upset the balance between slave and free states and possibly provoke a **federal move to abolish slavery**.



JOHN BROWN

THE MISSOURI COMPROMISE

This 1820 amendment to the Missouri statehood bill balanced admission of slave and free states, but in 1857 the Supreme Court ruled it unconstitutional, in favor of slave-owning states. With increasing numbers of free territories wishing to gain Union status, and an armed raid in 1859 by antislavery militant John Brown to free slaves at

Harpers Ferry, Virginia, the **southern states began to feel threatened**.

“The war is over—the **rebels** are our countrymen again.”

ULYSSES S. GRANT, 1865

slaves it would not arm) and greater resources. The Confederacy, however, had the better generals. Its simple strategy was to defend itself from attack and win recognition as an independent state. The Union government had no option but to attack the Confederacy by blockading its coastline and seizing its capital of Richmond, Virginia.

Both sides required troops and issued regular calls for volunteers. When numbers were insufficient, conscription was introduced, by the Confederacy in 1862, and the Union the next year. By the war's end, 50 percent of the eligible population in the Union had been mobilized, as were 75 percent of the Confederacy. Both armies were mainly white; Congress initially would not allow free African-Americans or escaped slaves—totaling about 500,000—to join the Union army, but changed the law after emancipation (the freedom of the slaves) in 1863. Almost 200,000 joined up, although they were paid less than white troops and could not become officers. In the Union, many women joined the Sanitary Commission, which ran kitchens and hospitals, and raised funds.

The American Civil War

In 1861 the United States split apart over the issue of slavery. It fought a lengthy, bloody civil war that lasted until 1865. Thousands were killed, and while the issue that caused the war was resolved, its divisive legacy lasted for years.

The catalyst for war was the election in November 1860 of the first Republican Party president, Abraham Lincoln (see pp.314–15), against a divided Democrat opposition. Lincoln opposed slavery in territories wishing to achieve Union membership, and won the votes of every free state (see BEFORE) but one. The southern states voted for a pro-slavery Democrat, John Breckenridge. The impact of the result was immediate.

On December 20, 1860, South Carolina voted to leave the Union. By June 1861, 10 more states had joined these rebels, known as the Confederacy, but not every slave state joined: Kentucky remained neutral, while Delaware, Maryland, and Missouri were loyal to the Union. Virginia joined the Confederacy, causing West Virginia to separate and become a Union state.

The first shots were fired by Confederate cannons on April 12, 1861; their target

was the Union-held Fort Sumter in Charleston Harbor, South Carolina. Three days later, Lincoln issued a call for loyal state governors to send 75,000 militia troops to protect Washington, DC. The war had begun.

A country divided

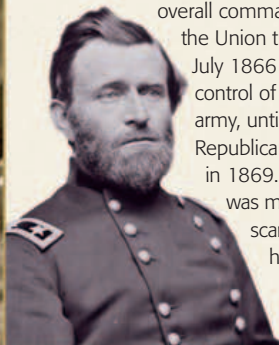
The two sides were not well matched; the Union had the larger population (22 million compared to 9 million in the South, of whom 3.5 million were

AMERICAN GENERAL (1822–85)

ULYSSES S. GRANT

Ulysses S. Grant trained at West Point military academy but failed to make a success of army life, and then saw his Missouri farm fail during the 1857 depression. His military training won him the rank of colonel when war broke out, and early successes and aggressive tactics—notably at Shiloh in 1862—earned him promotion. In March 1864 Grant was appointed by Lincoln as

overall commander of the Union troops. In July 1866 he took control of the US army, until becoming Republican president in 1869. His tenure was marred by scandal, but he held office until 1877.



Battle of Gettysburg

Total casualties for both sides at Gettysburg are estimated to have exceeded 46,000, with the dead left on the battlefield. This was the first conflict to be extensively documented by war photographers.

